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Project #38: ClinicalTrials.gov: building compliance within HFH

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Introduction

Clinicaltrials.gov became publicly available in 2005 and was created as a resource for patients, physicians, regulatory bodies, and funders to provide the most up-to-date information about clinical trials conducted throughout the nation. (1) Although motivated to comply with regulations, those tasked with maintaining records, found the website to be cumbersome and this has resulted in thousands of poorly maintained records. The Food and Drug Administration (FDA), has begun informing institutions and researchers of the potential incurred monetary penalties upwards of \$13,000 per day per record for failure to submit their clinical trial results. (2) As a High Reliability Organization, Henry Ford Health (HFH) has a commitment to research participants to provide safe and high-quality trials and provide scientific validity and transparency while meeting ethical standards. The desire and responsibility to meet the compliance mandate became a high priority for HFH leadership who sought support from the recently formed centralized Clinical Trials Office to lead the effort of identifying non-compliance, mitigating outstanding records, and tasked to develop a process to ensure compliance is established and maintained.

Actionable Items

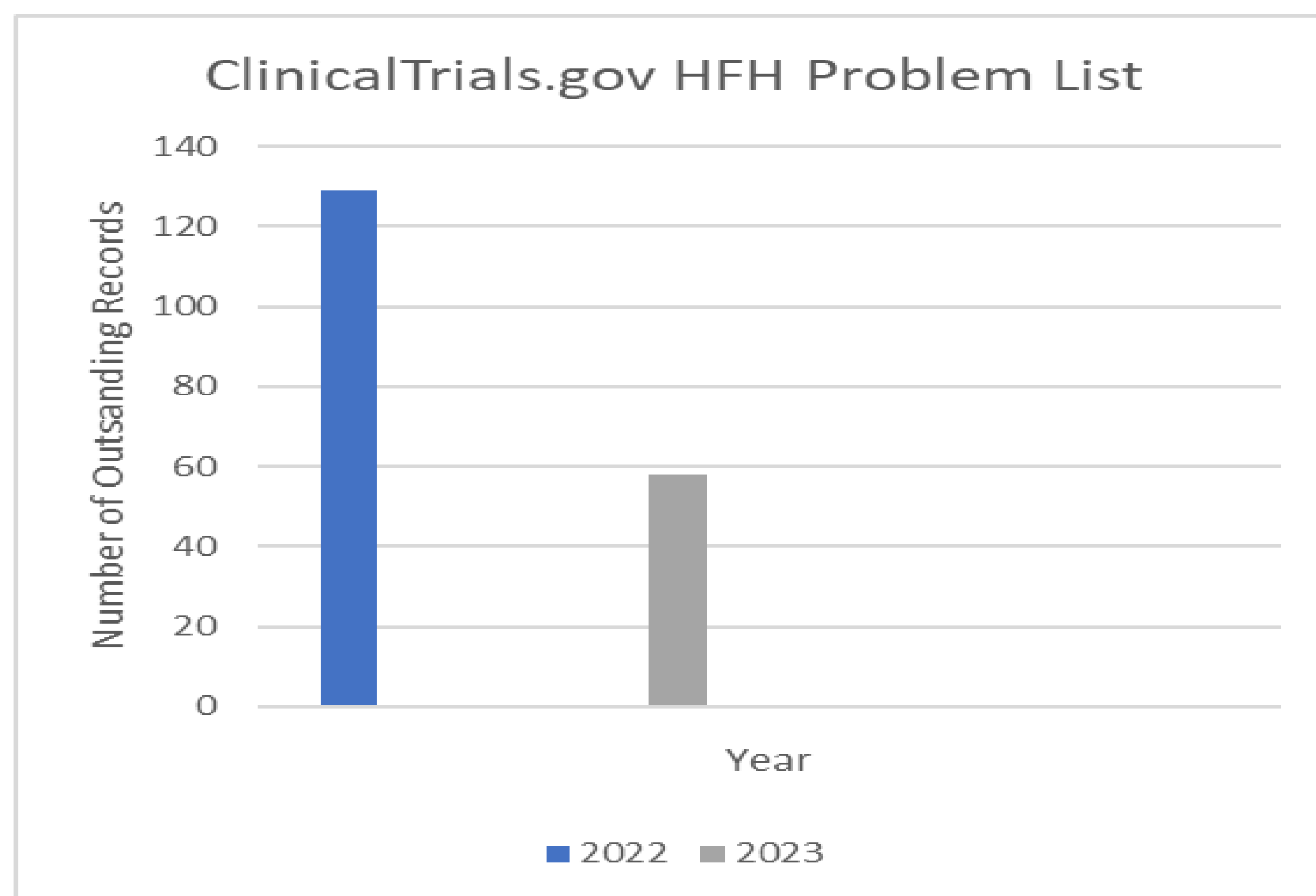
Late November 2022, members of the CTO were assigned administrator duties which allowed full access to the open records and the 129 studies on the Problem List

- Of those 129 study records, almost 20 percent were in violation of late results reporting per the FDAAA tracking site and therefore at risk of financial penalty
- Many of the 129 records had not been updated in over one year, with nine studies untouched for 5 years
- The CTO collaborated with the IRB for support in accessing IRB Manager and InfoEd, for older studies. Communication via email and telephone proved successful in connecting with many investigators and record owners responsible for addressing outstanding items and status.
- CTO staff in addition, took steps to learn more about how to navigate the clinicaltrials.gov worksite as well as locate educational resources to share.
- ClinicalTrials.gov is also undergoing a modernization project for both the public and PRS administrator websites to enhance user experience

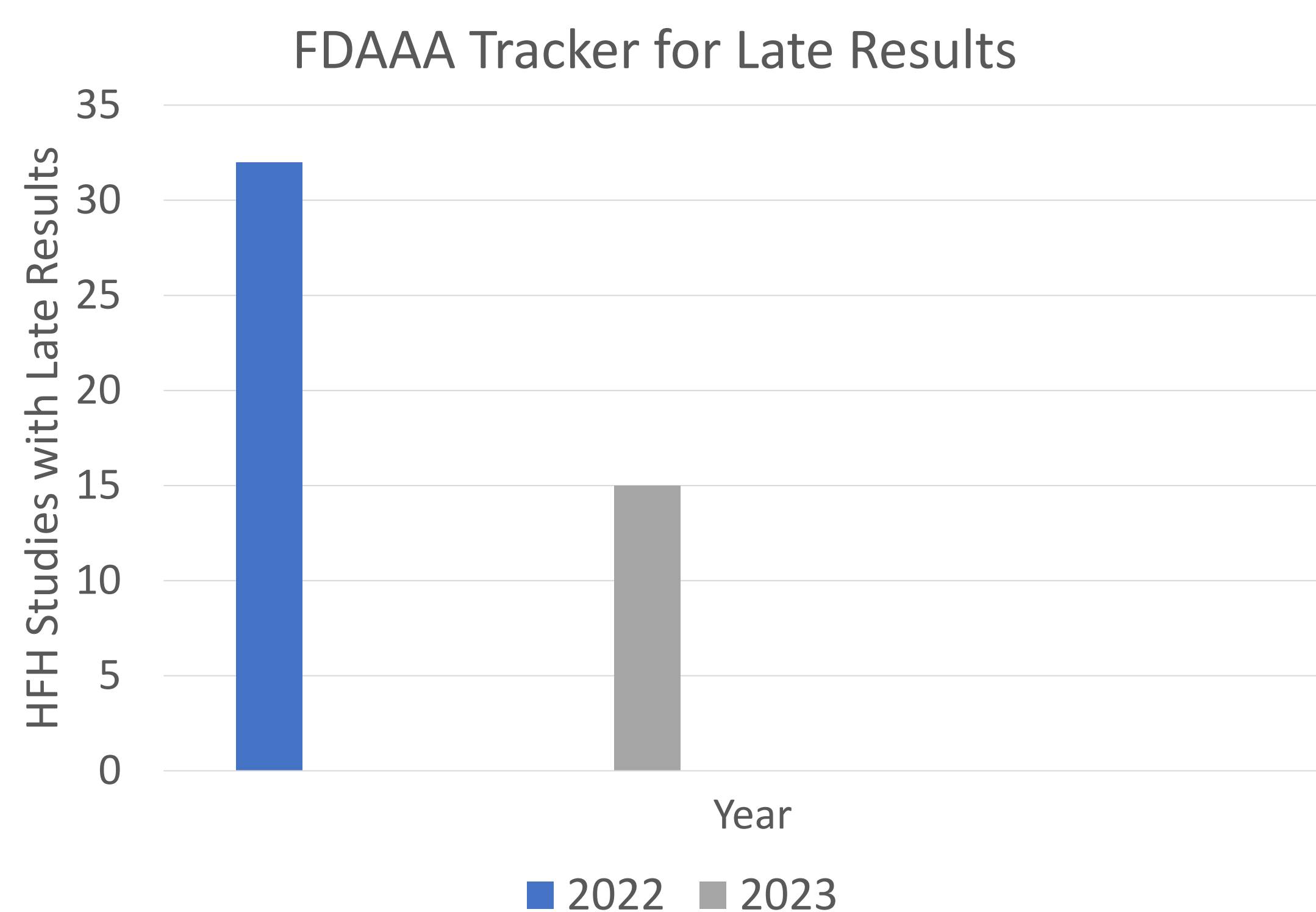
Results

Over subsequent months in 2023, as queries were resolved, the number of outstanding records on the Problem List decreased slowly from about 130 outstanding records to 58. This number will continue to reduce and realistically anticipate about 20 studies on the Problem List at any given time due to varying timelines and endpoints. A third-party tracking site monitors all studies listed on ClinicalTrials.gov that have failed to post results within the timeframe anticipated by the research team. With the reduction in outstanding records, this also reduced the number of late results. This tracking site is what the FDA could use in conjunction with ClinicalTrials.gov to incur the financial penalty on the responsible parties who are delinquent in results posting.

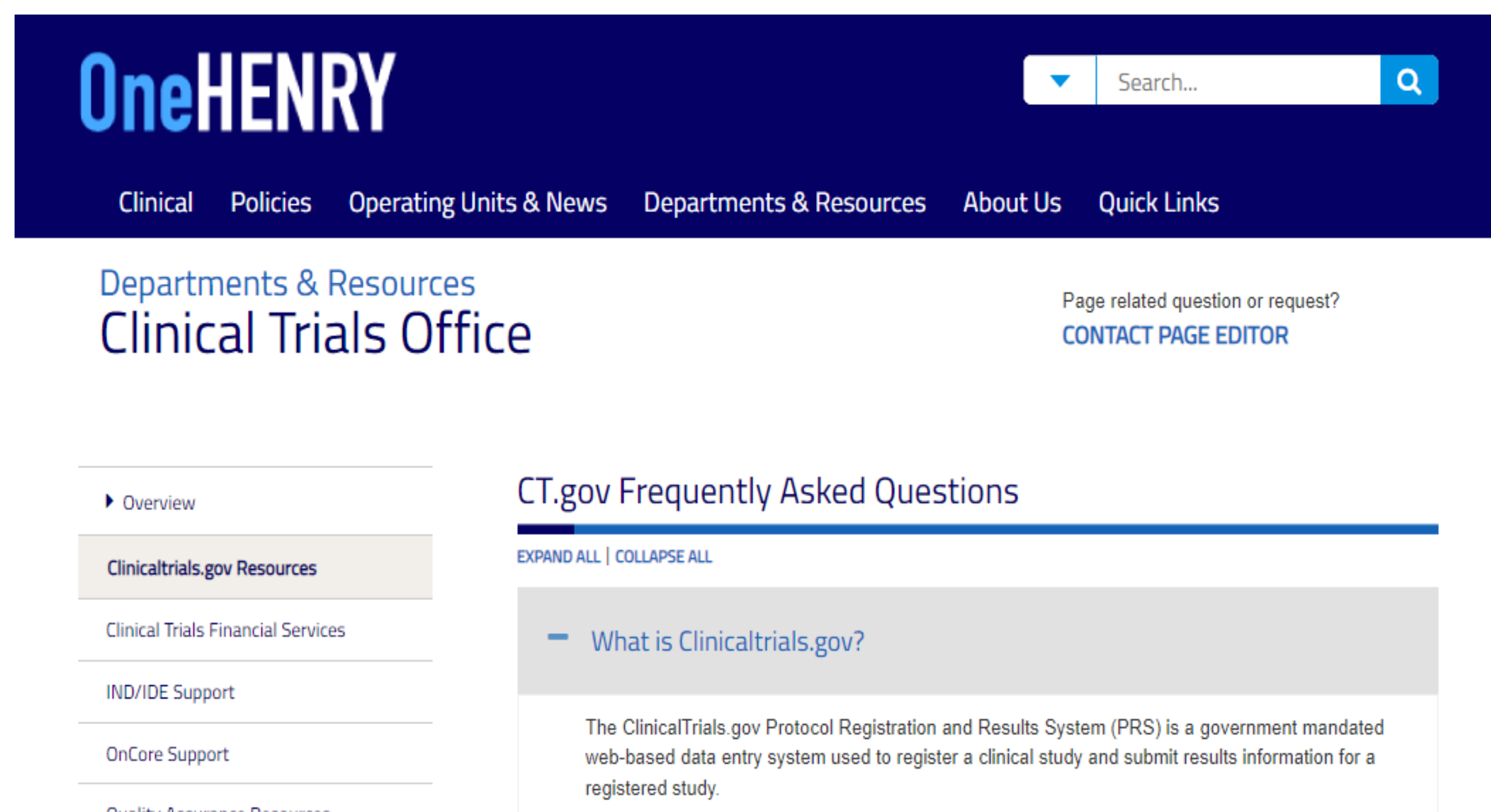
Studies on Problem List



FDAAA Tracker List



One Henry



Challenges Faced

- Several of the studies on the Problem List had been projects opened by residents that were no longer affiliated with Henry Ford Health. Without a transition process in place, the studies were not maintained, and often current staff had no familiarity with the study.
- Identifying a current investigator willing to take over ownership of the record and bring it back into compliance
- Many departments experienced staffing shortages in research after the pandemic and are slowly restaffing to accommodate these projects
- Per IRB policy, paper records of studies where the final report had been issued were destroyed after a certain period
- Researchers and support staff continue to experience problems with answering queries issued by the reviewers as updates are submitted
- Although the clinicaltrials.gov PRS website contains manuals and guides, one needs to be versed in statistics and data to provide accurate responses

Implementations

- Early into the cleanup project, it became clear that many institutions have also experienced this same overwhelming reality of delinquent records. The CTO believed it was imperative to create a policy as well as a centralized digital location to guide investigators in up-to-date information pertaining to clinicaltrials.gov
- Two policies regarding ClinicalTrials.gov were created and are maintained on the One Henry Clinical Trials Office webpage.
- The CTO webpage contains a section dedicated to ClinicalTrials.gov information for researchers within Henry Ford Health including links and guidance from multiple regulatory bodies.
- Internal escalation pathway created for accountability in responsiveness to outstanding queries. Working with IRB and Oncore CTMS to define workflow for studies requiring submission to ClinicalTrials.gov
- Although the CTO has multiple team members with administrative access to ClinicalTrials.gov, one team member dedicates regular service to this project as part of her responsibilities.

References

1. Clinical Trials (PRS) Protocol Registration System (Accessed on January 15, 2024, at <https://register.clinicaltrials.gov/prs>)
2. FDAAA Trials Tracker (Accessed on January 15, 2024, at <https://fdaaatrialstracker.net>)
3. 2024 CTTI Report – Improving Timely, Accurate, and Complete Registration and reporting of summary results information on clnicaltrials.gov (Accessed on January 18, 2024, at [CTTI SuggestedPractices ClinicalTrials-gov FINAL.pdf \(ctti-clinicaltrials.org\)](#))